

Foucault's theory of power

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An important step in understanding Foucault's broader projects is to understand his view of power.¹ Foucault's analyses of power are simultaneously articulated at two levels, the empirical and the theoretical. The first level is constituted by a detailed examination of historically specific modes of power and how these modes emerged out of earlier forms. Hence, he identifies modern forms of power, such as the closely related modes he termed "disciplinary power" and "biopower", and earlier, premodern forms such as "sovereign power". Indeed, much of his work on power is devoted to the task of articulating the emergence of later modes of power from earlier ones, and his analyses of disciplinary power in particular have been especially useful for subsequent scholars.

Three very simple examples can illustrate these forms of power. First, imagine a pyramid, with a king at the top, his ministers in the middle and the king's subjects (the people) at the bottom. If the king issues an edict, then his ministers will execute the order, imposing it upon the king's subjects. Traditionally, power has been understood as "being at the top of the pyramid"; and that was all that it was understood to be. But Foucault expands (indeed, totally reconceives) what constitutes power, and shows how this traditional view can be situated within a fuller understanding. He observed that in actual fact, power arises in all kinds of relationships, and can be built up from the bottom of a pyramid (or any structure). Thus, an academic transcript, the record of a student's courses and performance, becomes an instrument of power (how many times have you been told that "this will go on your permanent record"?), but begins from observation at the bottom of the pyramid, not from an edict from the top. Each and every student has a transcript, and this record of their performance, the fact that each one is observed (and not that the school has a principal), is what influences students' behaviour. The academic transcript is an instrument of disciplinary

power: it serves to make a student regulate or discipline her own performance and behaviour. Similarly, observing which groups in the population are most likely to contract a disease (such as lung cancer) can lead to a discovery of its causes (cigarette smoking, or asbestos exposure). Like academic transcripts, this third kind of power – in this case to save lives, by eliminating asbestos or smoke inhalation – does not require a “top of the pyramid” to function. But unlike an academic transcript, this kind of power does not directly address particular individuals, but rather groups of people and populations as a whole. This third example is an illustration of what Foucault calls “biopower”.

The second level of Foucault’s analyses (the “theoretical” level) transcends historical particularities and is common to the diverse modes of power that Foucault has described. It is at this level that we can grasp the most general and fundamental features of power and its operation, and so we would do well to approach Foucault’s work from this theoretical perspective.

Foucault’s most explicit thinking about power developed in the 1970s, particularly in two published works, *Discipline and Punish* (1975) and *La Volonté de Savoir* (1976, translated as *The History of Sexuality, Volume I: An Introduction*), as well as his courses at the Collège de France between 1974 and 1979. We will focus upon his most condensed and generalized presentation of power, Part Four of *La Volonté de Savoir*, to accomplish three tasks. First, we will be able to grasp why Foucault’s analyses can be called a “theory” of power. Second, we will identify the mistaken theories of power that his analysis is meant to supplant: the theories against which he is arguing. Third, we will be able to articulate the basic characteristics of power according to Foucault’s theory: a network of force relations throughout society, relations that are characterized by resistance and which interact by means of local tactics and larger strategies. Since these characteristics serve to describe not only modern forms of power such as disciplinary power, but also earlier forms, they represent the substance of Foucault’s *theory* of power.

A “theory” of power

What we can call a “theory” of power emerges from Foucault’s mid-1970s analyses of psychiatry, the prison and sexuality. This theory is not restricted to descriptions of one empirical period or “regime”, but describes certain general characteristics of power and its operation, across historical epochs and periods.

Foucault disliked the term “theory”. He noted in *La Volonté de Savoir* that “The aim of the inquiries that will follow is to move less toward a ‘theory’ of power than toward an ‘analytics’ of power ...” (1990a: 82; we will soon see how this sentence ends). Foucault emphasized analysis over theory in part because he was reluctant to make any claim to a permanent or complete understanding of the world in which we live. In his 1976 Collège de France course, Foucault explained at least part of his distrust for theory: “the question ‘What is power?’ is obviously a theoretical question that would provide an answer to everything, which is just what I don’t want to do” (2006a: 13). It is only in so far as theories can be used “untheoretically” in this sense – that is, without claiming to answer everything – that they can be valuable. Nevertheless, he did refer to his own project as a theory: his task “is a question of forming a different grid of historical decipherment by *starting from a different theory of power*” (1990a: 90–91, emphasis added).² For Foucault, then, the term “theory” must be used with caution; we should embrace theory only in the sense of “a theoretical production that does not need a visa from some common regime to establish its validity” (*ibid.*: 6).

With this terminological caution in mind, I shall use the term “theory” in an experimental sense: a theory is a hypothesis to organize diverse data, but also to be tested and revised or abandoned in light of that data. That a theory aims to be more general than a description of a single historical period or epoch is an essential part of its value and usefulness for our understanding of the phenomena it encompasses, and it is for these reasons that the term remains a useful term with respect to Foucault’s analyses of power. Such a theory does not “answer everything”; its warrant comes from the empirical data that it organizes and that supports it, and it is subject to revision.

Foucault’s theory of power suggests that power is omnipresent, that is, power can be found in all social interactions. As he put this in 1977, “it seems to me that power *is* ‘always already there’, that one is never ‘outside’ it” (1980e: 141). That power is omnipresent – that is, that power is co-extensive with the field of social relations; that power is interwoven with and revealed in other kinds of social relations – does *not* mean that power functions as a trap or cage, only that it is present in all of our social relations, even our most intimate and egalitarian.³ Nor is Foucault saying that all relations reduce to, or consist of nothing other than, power relations.⁴ Power does not “consolidate everything” or “embrace everything” or “answer everything”; power alone may not be adequate to explain all, or every aspect of, social relations. So Foucault’s theoretical task (and the

conclusion of the sentence we left earlier) is to work “toward an ‘analytics’ of power: that is, toward a definition of the specific domain formed by relations of power, and toward a determination of the instruments that will make possible its analysis” (1990a: 82).

How *not* to understand power

Foucault first distinguishes his own theory from three mistaken, inadequate or misleading conceptions of power (each of which corresponds to a tradition or school of social thought, as I note below in brackets).

[T]he word *power* is apt to lead to a number of misunderstandings – misunderstandings with respect to its nature, its form, and its unity. By power, I do not mean “Power” as a group of institutions and mechanisms that ensure the subservience of the citizens of a given state [such as characterize many liberal analyses]. By power, I do not mean, either, a mode of subjugation which, in contrast to violence, has the form of the rule [typical of psychoanalytic approaches]. Finally, I do not have in mind a general system of domination exerted by one group over another [i.e. class oppression], a system whose effects, through successive derivations, pervade the entire social body [as in many Marxist views].

(1990a: 92)

Foucault’s worry is not that these analyses are entirely useless, but that they often mischaracterize an accidental feature of power in a particular context as an essential characteristic of power in general.

The analysis, made in terms of power, must not assume that the sovereignty of the state [liberal], the form of the law [psychoanalytic], or the overall unity of a domination [Marxist] are given at the outset; rather, these are only the terminal forms power takes.

(*Ibid.*, my comments in brackets)

So each of these forms of power (sovereignty, law, domination) may in fact be present in certain contexts as terminal forms, but none are fundamental. And Foucault’s first task in understanding power is therefore to develop a new method – based on a richer theory – that begins with the basic molecules of

power relations and then builds to more complex forms.

The most important misconception is what Foucault terms a “juridico-discursive” understanding of power. This misconception, “deeply rooted in the history of the West”, is common to many “political analyses of power” (*ibid.*: 83) and approaches to sexuality. His argument is that this misconception, so generally accepted, has functioned as a mask by which much of the actual operation of power is obscured, thereby making many of the actual mechanisms of power tolerable (*ibid.*: 86).

According to this “juridico-discursive” theory, power has five principal characteristics: first, power always operates negatively, that is, by means of interdictions. Second, power always takes the form of a rule or law. This entails a binary system of permitted and forbidden, legal and illegal. These two characteristics together constitute the third: power operates through a cycle of prohibition, a law of interdiction. Hence (and fourth), this power manifests in three forms of prohibition – “affirming that such a thing is not permitted, preventing it from being said, denying that it exists” (*ibid.*: 84) – which reveal a logic of censorship. Fifth and finally, the apparatus of this power is universal and uniform in its mode of operation:

From top to bottom, in its overall decisions and its capillary interventions alike, whatever the devices or institutions on which it relies, it acts in a uniform and comprehensive manner; it operates according to the simple and endlessly reproduced mechanism of law, taboo, and censorship.

(*Ibid.*)

Notice how Foucault has characterized this uniformity, “in its overall decisions and its capillary interventions alike”. Implicit in this characterization is a distinction between macro-structures (the “overall decisions”) and micro-practices (“capillary interventions”): a distinction that will be very important in the development of Foucault’s own understanding of power. Recall our opening illustrations: a transcript would be a “capillary intervention”, whereas epidemiological studies of cancer rates reflect macro-patterns. Foucault’s analysis begins at the micro-level (in *Discipline and Punish*, for example) and is modified as it encompasses the macro-level (especially in the 1978 and 1979 Collège de France courses).⁵ That this distinction is not made in the “juridico-discursive” view is just another indication of how it differs from Foucault’s own analysis, and how it is mistaken about, and masks, the actual operation of power.

Why does Foucault term this view a “juridico-discursive” representation of power? First, it is juridical because it is modelled upon law, upon prohibition: “it is a power [more precisely a representation of power] whose model is essentially juridical, centered on nothing more than the statement of the law and the operation of taboos” (*ibid.*: 85). But as Foucault makes clear, the actual operation of power cannot be reduced to one model – the law, the state, or domination – but instead functions in a variety of forms and with varying means or techniques.

Second, according to this view, power is essentially discursive: its prohibitions are tied together with what one can say as much as what one can do; in this way restrictions on language should also function as restrictions upon reality and action – this is the heart of the “logic of censorship” (*ibid.*: 84). While this view emphasizes discourse as the primary arena in which power’s effects manifest, Foucault notes that discourses are related to power in much more complicated ways than this view would suggest: “Discourses are not once and for all subservient to power or raised up against it ... discourse can be both an instrument and an effect of power, but also a hindrance, a stumbling-block, a point of resistance and a starting point for an opposing strategy” (*ibid.*: 100–101).

Let us consider another example to illustrate this “juridico-discursive” view of power: is what you are wearing today an effect of power relations? If you picked your clothes to conform to a dress code (skirts must fall below the knee, no profanity on T-shirts, etc.), then your choices can be explained by a “juridico-discursive” account: a prohibitory, discursive law specified what you could or could not wear. Within those rules, on that view, your choices were presumably made without external interference. But when we look more closely, this view is not correct: a number of other, “capillary” (your friends) and “macro” (fashion) as well as extra-legal power relations have almost certainly shaped your choices of what to wear. Foucault’s own theory of power is meant to replace these “juridico-discursive” accounts:

It is this image that we must break free of, that is, of the theoretical privilege of law and sovereignty, if we wish to analyze power within the concrete and historical framework of its operation. We must construct an analytics of power that no longer takes law as a model and a code.

(*Ibid.*: 90)

A Foucauldian view of power

It is time now for us to turn to this constructive task, and begin to articulate Foucault's own positive understanding of power. Foucault's self-described task is to use empirical analyses to discover a new theory of power, which will in turn provide a new framework for (and the hypotheses to be tested in) subsequent historical analyses (Foucault 1990a: 90–91). He begins:

It seems to me that power must be understood in the first instance as [1] the multiplicity of force relations immanent in the sphere in which they operate and which constitute their own organization; as [2] the process which, through ceaseless struggles and confrontations, transforms, strengthens, or reverses them; as [3] the support which these force relations find in one another, thus forming a chain or a system, or on the contrary, the disjunctions and contradictions which isolate them from one another; and lastly, as [4] the strategies in which they take effect, whose general design or institutional crystallization is embodied in the state apparatus, in the formulation of the law, in the various social hegemonies.

(*Ibid.*: 92–3, my numerals)

There is much to unpack in this sentence. The bracketed numbers indicate four principal aspects of Foucault's initial definition. We have a set of "force relations", processes by which these relations are transformed, systems or disjunctions that are constituted by the interplay of these force relations, and larger strategies (or "terminal forms") with general and institutional characteristics that emerge from these relations, processes and systems. He begins at the micro-level, looking at local relations of force rather than at the macro-level of hegemonies and states, which can only be fully understood as functions of the local relations. In other words, Foucault begins with individuals' behaviours and interactions ("local relations" like academic transcripts, or choices of what to wear), to see how larger patterns, and eventually national norms or regulations, grow out of them.

First, then, power must be understood at the micro-level as relations of force. Foucault is unambiguous on this point: "It is in this sphere of force relations that we must try to analyze the mechanisms of power" (*ibid.*: 97). But what are these "force relations" at the basis of power? With this term, Foucault makes an explicit analogy to physics; he refers on numerous occasions, for example, to the

“microphysics of power” (1979: 26; 1990a: 16).⁶ Force relations seem to be the basic unit, the undefined or given, in this approach to power. Very broadly, force relations consist of whatever in one’s social interactions that pushes, urges or compels one to do something.

We can use the analogy to help us understand this notion of force relations as the basic unit of power. In Newtonian physics, force is defined as mass times acceleration. Force is thus the extent to which a body will be put into motion: larger objects (greater mass) will require a greater force to begin moving; a greater force will also be necessary to make an object move more quickly (greater acceleration). The important point here is that “force” is whatever serves to put an object into motion, *regardless* of the origin or source of that force. Force may be introduced by gravity, magnetism, or some other means. Its action thus can be described independently of any particular agent or object as the “creator” of that force. Analogously, Foucault speaks of power relations in terms of force relations without reference to a source or agent. This suggests that Foucault does *not* mean to imply that individuals cannot act as agents within power relations, but rather to draw our attention, especially for methodological reasons, to the force relations *as such* rather than to agents or actors. Closer examination of the characteristics of these force relations should help to make this clearer.

To recall, Foucault began with the claim that “power must be understood in the first instance as the multiplicity of force relations immanent in the sphere in which they operate and which constitute their own organization” (1990a: 92). Three features of these force relations are thus delineated, as follows.

First, that there is a multiplicity means that we will find many different relations of force, intersecting and overlapping, in our social interactions. What is more, this multiplicity suggests that these force relations will not all be of the same quality or kind: there will be multiple sorts of force relations, which may have different particular characteristics or impacts. To draw on the analogy to physics again, we could say that different forces will be present in the same field, as are gravity and magnetism, and that some of these forces will be stronger than others, and some stronger in certain contexts but not in others. To make this more concrete, recall (or imagine) yourself as a high school student, and consider what you chose to wear to school each day. You probably considered a number of different perspectives – or relations of force: what will my best friends say? Will a certain special someone think I look “cool” or “geeky” if she or he sees me in this? (Indeed, what constitutes “cool” or “geeky”

is defined through multiple overlapping relations.) What “group” (the “popular” set, jocks, brains, punks, skaters, etc.) does dressing like this put me in? Is it fashionable? What will my parents and teachers think? Is it in accord with the school’s official dress code? Most or all of these questions probably influenced your choice – whether you aimed to please or annoy any particular one of these groups – and they represent the very different, but intersecting relations within which you decide what to wear.

What sort of presence do these relations have then? The second feature delineated in this description is that force relations are “immanent in the sphere in which they operate”. That these relations are “immanent” means that they exist only within a certain domain or discourse. In other words, they are not concrete, like bodies, but incorporeal, like the laws of physics. They are nevertheless genuinely present – and, like laws, their presence can be felt in very concrete ways. The analogy to physics is again useful here. As physical bodies interact, they exert relations of gravity, magnetism and so on upon each other. Similarly, social interactions are constantly permeated by these relations of force, power relations. Foucault thus describes force relations as a “substrate”: “it is the moving substrate of force relations which, by virtue of their inequality, constantly engender states of power, but the latter are always local and unstable” (*ibid.*: 93). He notes in the 1976 Collège de France course that “power is never anything more than a relationship that can, and must, be studied only by looking at the interplay of the terms of the relationship” (2006a: 168).⁷ This means that power relations are not outside but rather “immanent in” other kinds (economic, knowledge, sexual) of relationships (1990a: 94). So “power is not an institution [or] a structure”, nor an individual capacity, but rather a complex arrangement of forces in society (*ibid.*: 93). Excepting an explicit dress code, none of the questions we asked above about what to wear could be answered institutionally, but they all have a significant impact on your status in school. And we are all quite aware of them, at least implicitly. Your choices of what to wear thus reveal “a complex strategical situation [how you want to be perceived by various groups] in a particular society [your school]”. And so your self-presentation has been shaped by power relations. This has an important corollary: power is omnipresent (as discussed above) “because it is produced from one moment to the next, at every point, or rather in every relation from one point to another. Power is everywhere; not because it embraces everything, but because it comes from everywhere” (*ibid.*: 93). It even shapes our choices of how to dress on a daily basis.

So there is a multiplicity of force relations, which are immanent in social

interactions. The third feature in this initial characterization is that these force relations “constitute their own organization”. On the one hand, these force relations “are the immediate effects of the divisions, inequalities, and disequilibriums which occur in [other types of relationships]” (*ibid.*: 94). But on the other hand,

If in fact [force relations] are intelligible, this is not because they are the effect of another instance that “explains” them, but rather because they are imbued, through and through, with calculation: there is no power that is exercised without a series of aims and objectives.

(*Ibid.*: 94–5)

Each school has its own distribution of social groups or cliques, with inequalities and occasionally shifting alliances. These calculations, these aims and objectives, which Foucault will refer to as tactics and strategy, constitute the internal organization of power relations.

Several other propositions also emerge from this core understanding of power. Foucault delineates five. First, since power emerges in relationships and interactions, power is not possessed, but exercised. “It is not the ‘privilege,’ acquired or preserved, of the dominant class, but the overall effect of its strategic positions” (*ibid.*: 26). At stake here are two competing models of power: one based on a contract (possession), the other based on perpetual battle (strategies or war). As he notes in *Discipline and Punish*, his analysis of power “presupposes that the power exercised on the body is conceived not as a property, but as a strategy . that one should take as its model a perpetual battle rather than a contract regulating a transaction or the conquest of a territory” (1979: 26). Second, reiterating the point about immanence, power relations are not exterior to other relations.

Third, “power comes from below; that is, there is no binary and all-encompassing opposition between rulers and ruled at the root of power relations and serving as a general matrix” (1990a: 94). So power is not reducible to a binary relationship (we cannot reduce all sorts of power to one model); furthermore, power comes from below (as discussed above, a multiplicity of power relations exist; power emerges from a variety of overlapping and intertwined relationships rather than from a sovereign individual).

That power comes from below means we cannot best understand power by looking at monarchies or states, at the top of any chain of command. Rather, we

must look at the complex webs of interwoven relationships: what Foucault calls the “microphysics” of power (1979: 26). Power develops in the first instance in specific, local, individual choices, behaviours and interactions. These combine in myriad ways to constitute larger social patterns, and eventually yield macroforms, which one typically thinks of when one thinks about “power” (societies, states, kings) – just as everyday objects are constituted by atoms and molecules. We thus have a micro-level of individuals (disciplinary techniques of the body) and a macro-level of populations (biopolitics).

Fourth of the five propositions that emerge from Foucault’s conception of power is that “power relations are both intentional and nonsubjective” (1990a: 94). This juxtaposition is, frankly, puzzling, and this claim has led to a fair amount of misunderstanding about Foucault’s analysis. First, power is intentional: power relations are “imbued, through and through, with calculation: there is no power that is exercised without a series of aims and objectives” (*ibid.*: 95). What you wear says much about you, and your status at school – not to mention your broader socioeconomic status (not everyone can afford designer labels) – and you have intentionally chosen to communicate a number of messages with your clothing. Foucault refers to these aims and objectives as “tactics” and “strategies”, and notes that these are what constitute its “rationality”. But power, he insists here, is also nonsubjective: “But this does not mean that it results from the choice or decision of an individual subject” (*ibid.*: 95). Nor, he continues, can it be located in groups such as economic decision makers, governing castes or the state apparatus. No one student, or social caste, or administrator can control what will be “cool” or “loser”. Indeed, what is “cool” today could be “out” tomorrow, and an out-group can rise in prestige (or vice versa).

The problem here, the apparent paradox, is that according to Foucault’s description, power has to be exercised by someone or something, but if it is nonsubjective, there cannot be a “someone” exercising that power. Foucault seems to be erasing agency – individuals’ capacity to choose and act for themselves – or rather, locating this capacity to act in a noncorporeal “power” rather than in individuals and institutions. It is as if “power”, not you, decides what you are wearing today. I think this problem can be resolved with two observations. First, part of his point here is that the effects of the exercise of power reach beyond any individual’s (or group’s) intentions or control. As we have already seen, Foucault is arguing against the view that “the state” acts as a monolith, and he is arguing for the importance of micro-events, with their ripples and interactions, in order to understand macro-phenomena. This means that local

actions often have unintended macro-consequences, and that one's control of macro-processes will always be limited and incomplete. Macro-phenomena result from the concatenation of many micro-events, but they are not the direct result of any *particular* individual action or choice. This is, then, an argument for a systemlevel, rather than individual-level, understanding of power relations. Foucault's distinction between tactics and strategy parallels this micro/macro distinction. Tactics are local, micro (individual choices about what to wear today); and strategies are macro, systemic (school-or culture-wide understandings of "cool" and "uncool").

The second observation to be made here is a logical one. To understand subjectivity as constituted (in part) through power relations is not to deny that subjects can act intentionally. You still choose what you'll wear each day, even if those choices are conditioned and limited by the "strategical situation" in which you find yourself. Given this problem, the status of subjectivity will become a focal point of Foucault's investigations in later years. It is an important point, because one of the fundamental questions for ethical action has to do with the individual's ability to make decisions that are not "merely" determined by the relations of power in which they emerge – in other words, a question of freedom.

This question may in fact lie at the heart of readers' varied reactions to Foucault's analyses. Those who understand the claim that individuals are constituted by power relations to constitute a denial of freedom find his vision to be bleak. Those of us, on the other hand, who find in his analyses the tools with which to increase our self-awareness, and hence our own freedom, hear wellsprings of hope in his discussion of the continuous transformations of power through history. (Understanding how "cool" comes to be defined and how certain groups are "cooler" than others, one can – perhaps even through one's choice of clothes – begin to break free of or even redefine these categories and groups.) At a minimum, on the latter view, if power relations are in fact best understood as a necessarily ongoing battle, then the battle is never utterly lost.

Indeed, Foucault seems to anticipate this objection, this worry about freedom, in the fifth of five propositions that he discusses here. Power is always accompanied by resistance; resistance is in fact a fundamental structural feature of power: "Where there is power, there is resistance, and yet, or rather consequently, this resistance is never in a position of exteriority in relation to power" (1990a: 95). Without resistance, without two bodies (or minds) pushing or pulling against each other, there is no power relation. And through resistance,

power relations can always be altered.

This fifth point encapsulates each of the preceding four. Power is exercised (first proposition) in the very interplay of force and resistance; this interplay is present in all social interactions (second proposition); force and resistance are manifest even in micro-interactions between individuals as well as states (third proposition); and while each person may choose to apply force or resist, the ultimate outcome of the relation cannot be controlled by one party (power is intentional and nonsubjective – fourth proposition).

On the role of resistance in constituting power, Foucault's position will not change. In a 1984 interview, for example, Foucault reiterates that "in the relations of power, there is necessarily the possibility of resistance, for if there were no possibility of resistance – of violent resistance, of escape, of ruse, of strategies that reverse the situation – there would be no relations of power" (1994: 12). He adds that "there cannot be relations of power unless the subjects are free ... [I]f there are relations of power throughout every social field it is because there is freedom everywhere" (*ibid.*: 12).

Let us stop for a moment and recall where we are in the discussion. We began this section with a long quotation, in which Foucault identified four principal aspects of power.⁸ Our discussion so far has focused on explicating only the first of these, that power consists of multiple force relations. (We have covered a good deal of ground along the way. Indeed, we have implicitly addressed the other three aspects of power.)

The second aspect that Foucault identifies here is that these force relations are processes, not static, and are constantly being transformed. These transformations take the form of ceaseless struggles and confrontations – between the original force and its accompanying resistance – and sometimes strengthen the power relations, but sometimes weaken or reverse it. These processes also produce a number of interrelationships and systems, as various power relations reinforce or undermine each other (third aspect). Here Foucault introduces a distinction between tactics and strategy: tactics are the local rationalities of power in particular cases; strategies, on the other hand, are the larger systemic or global patterns of power. And (fourth aspect) these strategies are built out of combinations and concatenations of those local tactics.

[T]he rationality of power is characterized by tactics that are often quite explicit at the restricted level where they are inscribed ... tactics which, becoming connected to one another, attracting and propagating one another,

but finding their base of support and their condition elsewhere, end by forming comprehensive systems.

(1990a: 95)

These comprehensive systems, or strategies, constitute “institutional crystallizations” out of the interaction and combination of locally fluid power relations, and become recognizable terminal forms like the state and the other types he enumerated.

The movement of Foucault’s analysis here is from the micro-level to the macro, from the molecular to the everyday – from (1) specific, individual force relations through (2) their processes of transformation and (3) the networks or systems that their interplay produces, to (4) their larger, strategic manifestations in the state, the law and other hegemonies, such as ownership of the means of production. In the end-forms that Foucault identifies here, we should recognize the three traditions of analysis that Foucault earlier criticized as partial and inadequate (liberalism, psychoanalysis, Marxism). Even though each of these strategies may be one-dimensional, the networks of power taken in sum are multi-dimensional and cannot be reduced to only one strategic mode, “juridico-discursive” or otherwise. Foucault’s point is that while they may have adequately described some particular strategy (or terminal form) of power, each approach fails to grasp the fundamental form or operation of power at the molecular level. But as Foucault reminds us again, analysis of power must begin not with these end-forms, but with “the moving substrate of force relations which, by virtue of their inequality, constantly engender states of power” (*ibid.*: 93). Observing power in its local and peripheral effects provides a new viewpoint from which to begin a study of power, and will thus entail a new methodological approach: the theory of power that we have just outlined.

An ongoing project

To review, we have unpacked a dozen or so dense pages at the heart of *La Volonté de Savoir*. What we have discussed provides only a *basic framework*: a set of theoretical presuppositions that constitutes the heart of Foucault’s theory of power. There are important elements of this theory that we have not discussed, and many aspects of Foucault’s analysis of power would continue to evolve over the next decade, as Foucault’s ongoing self-critique continued. This

basic framework, however, is consistent throughout the theory's subsequent development and elaboration.

Notes

- 1 Special thanks to David Cylkowski, Stacy Klingler and Dianna Taylor for their very thoughtful responses to earlier versions of this essay.
- 2 The French original is at Foucault (1976: 120): "en se donnant une autre théorie du pouvoir".
- 3 These are not necessarily the same relationships.
- 4 Lynch (1998) gives a fuller discussion of Foucault's view of the omnipresence of power.
- 5 For more on this shift, see Lynch (2009).
- 6 We must be careful not to make too much of the analogy to physics; I do not think, for example, that Foucault means that analysis of social relations should be reduced to equations of force relations. Given this caution, however, we can note certain implications of the analogy.
- 7 In this passage, Foucault is making an observation about Henri de Boulainvilliers' eighteenth-century history of France. But his point here, in fact, speaks to Foucault's own methodology.
- 8 On page 19, above.